



Everyone's heard of Linux, most fear it, but the few daring individuals that use it, now swear by it. Is there a Linux distribution that can compare with Windows' functionality, leave alone replace it as the OS of choice? Let's find out...

"Hello everybody... I'm doing a (free) operating system (just a hobby, won't be big and professional...)." Linus Torvalds' first Linux announcement on August 25, 1991.

Those simple words describe Linux's humble beginning. Linux comes in various distributions (distros to the geekdom) that promise to be stable, and as user friendly as Windows. Well, are these just empty assurances, or can their claims be justified? The purpose of this comparison test was to evaluate the very best of these Linux distros. We also answer crucial questions that every office and home user wants answered—is Linux really ready for the desktop? Can I install Linux on my PC, and get the same productivity, and features that Windows offers? Can I transparently work with my existing data under Linux? This test answers them all, and comes up with some astonishing results to boot.

The available flavours were divided into two categories: Windows replacements, and Office Desktops.

The Windows replacement distributions are meant for a newbie scouting the market for an OS other than Windows. We chose Xandros, Lycoris, Lindows 3.0 and ELX Linux, for this category.

The second category includes distributions that do not attempt to give the same look-n-feel as the standard Windows desktop. Instead, they provide a very intuitive interface that can be used with little effort. They also bundle a whole lot of applications that make life easier for the office user. Red Hat Linux 9.0, Mandrake 9.1, and SuSE Linux Office Desktop were the distributions considered.

How we tested

The test process for the categories was almost identical. However, the weightage awarded to each component of the test process differed for the two categories. For Windows replacements, importance was given to their resemblance to Windows so that a novice user can make the right choice.

The Linux Shootout